



The Male Imagination in Literature and Cinema: Asaf Halet Çelebi's Poem "My Woman" and the Film Don't Worry My Darling

The Male Imagination in Literature and Cinema: Asaf Halet Çelebi's Poem "My Woman" and the Film Don't Worry My Darling

Caner SOLAK



Erzurum Technical University, Faculty of Letters,
Department of Turkish Language and Literature,
Erzurum, Türkiye



Received Date/Received: 13.12.2024
Revision Requested/Revision Requested: 04.03.2025
Last Revision/Last Revision: Accepted: 12.06.2025
Date/Accepted: 24.04.2025

Publication Date/Publication Date: 24.09.2025

Corresponding Author/Corresponding Author: Caner SOLAK
E-mail: canersolak86@hotmail.com

Cite this article as: Solak, C. (2025). The male imagination in literature and cine-ma: Asaf Halet Çelebi's poem "My Wo-man" and the film Don't Worry My Dar-ling. *Art and Interpretation*, 46, 38-44.



Content of this journal is licensed under a
Creative Commons Attribution-
NonCommercial 4.0 International License.

ABSTRACT

This study offers a comparison between Asaf Halet Çelebi's poem "Kadıncığım" and the 2022 film Dert Etme Sevgilim (Don't Worry My Darling), focusing on the patriarchal mindset's desire to idealize and control women. Building on Lacan's view that "Woman does not exist," the analysis argues that women are constructed as reflections of the male imagination and that this mindset frequently finds expression in literature and cinema. Beginning with the Pygmalion myth in Greek mythology, the study addresses men's desire to create the ideal woman from a historical perspective.

In the poem "Kadıncığım," the male figure creates a female figure "by removing his hip bone" in order to complete his own lack. Yet this figure is positioned solely as an object that satisfies the man's desires. Similarly, in the film Dert Etme Sevgilim, Jack imprisons his wife Alice within a virtual world and transforms her into his ideal spouse. By defining women in terms of functionality, these two works offer a critique of a mindset that erases female individuality and turns women into beings made to serve male domination.

Both works emphasize the unsustainability of patriarchal utopias. While the woman created in Çelebi's poem "Kadıncığım" becomes a reflection of a cycle of loneliness and domination, in the film Dert Etme Sevgilim Alice escapes the world in which she is confined and regains her freedom. This suggests that men's desire to control women will, sooner or later, end in failure.

The shared point of the works is their critique of power dynamics in relations between women and men and their demonstration that the ideal-woman fantasies produced by men are socially destructive. The study argues that women's desire for freedom will, sooner or later, bring such domination-based structures to collapse. It becomes apparent that men's ideal-woman fantasies constitute a prison for both men and women. Both works thus provide a forceful critique of power dynamics in women's and men's relations and of the consequences of domination.

Keywords: Literature, cinema, Asaf Halet Çelebi, Kadıncığım, Dert Etme Sevgilim

ABSTRACT

This study presents a comparative analysis of Asaf Halet Çelebi's poem Kadıncığım ("My Little Wo-man") and the 2022 film Don't Worry Darling in terms of the patriarchal mindset's desire to idealize and control women. Drawing on Lacan's famous assertion that "The Woman does not exist," the analysis posits that women are constructed as projections of male imagination and argues that this perspective frequently appears in literature and cinema. The study explores the historical roots of the male desire to create the ideal woman, beginning with the myth of Pygmalion from Greek mythology. In Kadıncığım, the male subject creates a female figure by "removing his femur" to compensate for his lack. However, this figure is positioned solely as an object that fulfills male desires. Similarly, in Don't Worry Darling, Jack confines his wife, Alice, to a virtual world, transforming her into his ideal spouse. Both works critique a mindset that erases female individuality and reduces women to functional entities serving male dominance.

Both works also highlight the unsustainability of patriarchal utopias. In Kadıncığım, the created wo-man becomes a reflection of the loneliness and cycle of domination inherent in male fantasies, while in Don't Worry Darling, Alice breaks free from her imposed confinement, reclaiming her autonomy. This underscores the inevitable failure of male attempts to control women.

The shared theme in both works lies in their critique of power dynamics in gender relations and the destructive societal implications of male fantasies about the "ideal woman." The study argues that women's yearning for freedom will eventually dismantle such oppressive systems. It concludes that these fantasies of ideal womanhood ultimately imprison both men and women, offering a powerful critique of the consequences of patriarchal control in gender relations

Keywords: Literature, cinema, Asaf Halet Çelebi, Kadıncığım, Don't Worry Darling

Introduction

Jacques Lacan’s famous assertion, formulated as “The Woman does not exist,” rests on the idea that femininity is a product of male imagination and fantasy. For Lacan, woman is constructed through the roles and meanings attributed to her by the male mind; rather than possessing a “real” essence, she is a reflection of men’s subjective fantasies. This idea has found a place across many fields of literature and art, and men’s desire to create the idealized female figure has appeared in different forms throughout the ages. In this context, the Pygmalion legend in Greek mythology constitutes an archaic example of the desire to create the ideal woman of male fantasy.¹Pygmalion, a Cypriot sculptor, makes a flawless statue of a woman and falls in love with it. When the goddess Aphrodite brings this statue to life, his dreams become reality. Yet this story reflects not only an individual love, but also the deep roots of a patriarchal mindset that constructs woman as a controllable, ideal figure.

This myth was reinterpreted in Bernard Shaw’s famous play *Pygmalion*, and addressed within the framework of modern social critique. Through the character of Henry Higgins, Shaw questions the refashioning of a woman by a man and her being made to conform to social norms.²However, such works show that the effort to create the ideal woman is not confined to mythology or art alone; they demonstrate that men’s desire to establish domination over women and to shape them in accordance with their own wishes is a universal theme.

This study examines the fantasy of creating the woman of male imagination through Asaf Halet Çelebi’s poem “Kadıncığım” and the film *Dert Etme Sevgilim*. In both works, it will be discussed how a patriarchal perspective shapes the desire to reduce women to objects and to idealize them. The Pygmalion myth and Lacan’s perspective of woman as a male fantasy provide a theoretical ground for analyzing these works. The unsustainability of men’s domination over women and the collapse of this imaginary world will be interrogated throughout the study.

Asaf Halet Çelebi’s Poem “Kadıncığım” KADINCIĞIM

by removing my thigh bone
I made myself a little woman and,
giving her a slap,
I sat her on the shelf

when I left the house
my little woman cooked my meals,
stitched my tears

and when evening came
out of fear she
got up and sat on the
shelf

at nights I rest my head on my little woman’s knees and
when I pluck three hairs
I fall asleep (Çelebi, 1998, p. 15)

Asaf Halet Çelebi’s poem “Kadıncığım” offers a symbolic narrative of the male mind’s construction of the ideal woman. The poem addresses the man’s attempt to create a woman through his own lack, while also thematizing a kind of domination and a cycle of loneliness produced by this act of creation. The poem’s opening line—“I took out my pelvic bone and made myself a little woman”—provides a point of departure open to numerous mythological, religious, and psychoanalytic readings. Here, the man enters a process of creation by using a part of his own body in order to compensate for his deficiency. In this context, a parallel may be drawn with the Torah³ account in which Eve is created from Adam’s rib. “The relationship between man and birth can, of course, be established only through the man’s role as the one who impregnates the woman. Yet another point that should not be forgotten is that in the ‘creation myth’ that forms the basis of the monotheistic religions, the first human is Adam and Eve is formed from his body. In other words, in a sense, the first to give birth is a man. Adam gave birth to Eve. Yet in the process he loses a rib” (Parman, 2006, p. 27). As Talat Parman indicates, Adam—who performs this symbolic first birth—loses one of his ribs during creation, which in turn produces an imagination of lack grounded in masculinity (Parman, 2006, p. 27).

From this perspective, we can relate the process of creation in the poem to Otto Rank’s view that “the artist creates people who resemble himself.” Rank argues that the artist continually enters a process of new birth, and that through these creative pains reconstructs the self anew within the work (Rank, 2011, p. 135). A similar process is observable in Çelebi’s poem: the man, on the one hand, seeks to complete his missing parts, while on the other hand becomes trapped between this lack and the effort to achieve completion.

The female figure in Çelebi’s poem is neither fully a beloved nor an equal individual; rather, she is a being who serves the man’s desires. Defining the woman through actions such as “she cooked my meals” and “she sewed my tears” emphasizes that her existence is circumscribed by functionality. The poet’s statement “I slapped her and sat her on the shelf” shows that this created being is also subjected to control and domination. In Ece Serrican Kabalci’s reading, this type of woman is “docile and meets the man’s needs,” yet is also a figure who possesses the knowledge of how to exhaust the man’s power (Kabalci, 2019, p. 995).

In the poem’s third stanza, the lines “at nights I rest my head on my little woman’s knees / and when I pluck three hairs, I fall asleep” imply that the female figure is a being through whom the man finds peace, yet also one who is worn down as the cost of that peace. Here, the motif of “plucking three hairs” can be read as a metaphor of both power and consumption. These lines also contain a rich field of meanings in mythological and psychoanalytic terms. They indicate a relationship in which the man approaches the woman with both a desire for comfort and an impulse to control, while simultaneously construing her existence as a kind of talismanic force. In particular, the motif of “plucking three hairs” can be interpreted in both mythological and ritual contexts. In mythology, hair frequently represents power, fate, and spiritual energy. In this sense, “three hairs” may signify wholeness, balance, or the completion of a particular cycle. After the three hairs are plucked, the man reaches a feeling of relief or completion by “sleeping.” This suggests that the woman is not only a source of solace but also a being that carries a kind of ritual significance for the man. In the poem

1 For the appearances of this narrative in mythology, literature, cinema, and psychology, see: (Egrik, 2007, pp. 4-127).
2 For reflections of the Pygmalion narrative in Turkish literature, see: (Çağın, 2021, pp. 127-148).
3 “In the Qur’an, it is stated that the first human was created from earth, mud, and clay in the verses al-Mu’minun/12, ar-Rahman/14, Ali İmran/59, as-Sajda/7, al-An’am/2, al-Hajj/5, and al-Hijr/26. The creation of woman is addressed in an-Nisa/1. This verse says that the human being and his spouse were created from a single soul. In this verse and in none of the other verses is the name Eve mentioned. Moreover, there is no information indicating that the first woman was created from Adam’s rib. However, in some exegeses of the verse, in Islamic sources such as al-Tabari’s History, in narratives of the story of Prophet Adam, and in many Islamic accounts, a theme similar to that in the Torah appears. It has been stated that such narratives have no original basis; rather, elements not belonging to Islam—referred to with terms such as Isra’iliyyat and Islamic mythology—have in some way become embedded within Islamic narratives and even within exegetical works. In the Torah, it is also written that the first human was created from earth (Genesis, Chapter 2/7). The creation of woman, however, is explained in more detail than in the Qur’an (Genesis, Chapter 2/18-24). Accordingly, God decides to create a spouse for Adam so that he will not remain alone. He does this by taking a piece from Adam’s rib bone. In this respect, the story here overlaps with certain exegeses and Islamic mythology” (Daştan, 2014, pp. 65-66).

“to rest my head on my little woman’s knees” may point to the man’s search for a mother figure or a source of consolation. Sleep generally signifies relaxation and a transition into the unconscious. Through the little woman’s presence and the three hairs he plucks from her, the man attains peace in the unconscious. This can be associated with his viewing the woman’s existence as a kind of assurance and a source of comfort.

Through a female figure created as the object of male desire, the poem “Kadinciğim” offers a forceful critique of power dynamics in women–men relationships, male domination, and the loneliness inherent in that domination. According to Bilal Kırımlı, “In the poem ‘Kadinciğim,’ there is, rather than a woman, a type of woman who resembles the fairies seen in certain tales—one who is ready to comply with all his commands. In this poem, what emerges is not a woman who is loved, but a woman who is ruled over” (Kırımlı, 1994, p. 185). We may thus argue that the poet’s imaginary “little woman” is in fact a product of the male mind—an unreal construct created to alleviate the man’s loneliness, to benefit from her functions, and to maintain constant control.

Men’s Utopia: The Film *Dert Etme Sevgilim*

The *Dert Etme Sevgilim* film, originally titled *Don’t Worry Darling* (2022), is set in Victory, an idealized settlement in 1950s America. In this world, men leave the center en masse each day to work on the mysterious Victory Project, while women remain at home and live a luxurious, orderly life. The film depicts a lifestyle in which men work and all women are housewives. Everyone in this community lives in detached houses with gardens. Victory residents’ food, the goods they need, and their furniture are provided by the Victory Project. The main character, Alice, is part of this community with her husband Jack. Although Alice initially believes that Victory offers a flawless life, over time she begins to question the reality behind this order. After a woman in the community dies by suicide, Alice becomes curious about the boundaries of Victory, which lies in the desert. Following what she experiences upon entering a forbidden zone while investigating a plane crash, she starts to interrogate her life and claims that they are being kept inside a simulation. Due to the dreams, hallucinations, and contradictory rules she encounters, Alice comes to believe that Frank, the community’s leader, has constructed a virtual world within the framework of his patriarchal ideology. However, as her friends and her husband call her mental state into question, Alice’s perception of reality begins to weaken. By the end of the film, it becomes clear that Victory is in fact a modern dystopian experiment: men have abducted their wives from the real world and are keeping their consciousness under control there. Jack, too, has imprisoned Alice in this world without her consent. Alice, even if unwillingly, kills her husband Jack and attempts to escape this artificial world. Although Frank and the other men intervene to protect the simulation, the film ends with the sound of Alice breathing in the real world.

Alice and the Other Women

The film *Don’t Worry Darling* opens by depicting the daily routines of housewives who cheerfully do housework, go shopping together, take ballet lessons as a group, chat, and live in a perpetual summer season. While the protagonist’s name, Alice, is an allusion to the novel *Alice in Wonderland*, the film’s Alice, too, has passed into a new world through a virtual tunnel composed of symmetrical images and suggestions that she is forced to watch without being able to close her eyes.

Like Alice, the other women living in this virtual world cannot remember many details about their lives before arriving there. Information such as how they met their husbands, where they went on their honeymoon, or their hometowns has been fabricated as similar variations of the same story. The main purpose is to prevent the women from recalling their real identities.

In the film, the desire for freedom among women appears to be almost contagious. Just as the sense that everything she experiences is fake is transmitted to Alice from her neighbor Margaret—whose suicide she witnesses—Alice’s awakening will, in turn, spread from her to the other women. Alice’s sense that the world she inhabits is a simulation made up of codes begins when the eggs she cracks while preparing breakfast repeatedly turn out to be empty inside. The emptiness of these eggs—which can be regarded as symbols of the soul—signifies that this formally perfect, meticulously designed world is not real.

There are two women who live in this virtual world by their own consent. The reason Alice’s neighbor Bunny does not question the system and remains satisfied despite knowing how it works is that she lost her children in the real world. Benefiting from this possibility offered by virtual reality, Bunny says of her children, “They’re alive here.” As we understand at the end of the work, Shelley, the wife of Frank—the founder of the system—is also among the architects of this world.

Frank and the Men: The Idealization of Power

On the wall of the hall where the women conduct their ballet rehearsals, Frank’s portrait hangs high up, reminiscent of a head of state. Throughout the day, Frank’s teachings are broadcast on radio and television. Because he seemingly grants people the life of their dreams, a veritable cult of Frank has formed. It is evident that the reverence for Frank is much stronger among men. During a meet-and-greet party Frank hosts in the garden of his house, the following exchange takes place among the men:

“I didn’t get to talk to Frank much.

-Frank doesn’t need to talk to you.

-Sorry, I—

-You don’t know how magnificent he is, what he can do. You’re lucky even to know who he is, let alone be in his house.

-I just got excited. I’m sorry.”

Members who reach certain stages are given a copy of Frank’s ring. Among these men, it functions as a status symbol. Frank keeps the men in the system within his sphere of influence through statements such as: “Modern society has suffocated our true personalities and distanced us from our biological aim. I see the version of you that you have buried deep and that others do not see. This is the real you.” They gaze admiringly at the ring that represents Frank and kiss it. We also see that Jack trusts Frank more than he trusts his wife. The reason for this relationship of admiration between Frank and the men can be explained as follows: Frank has offered the men in the film the virtual paradise they have always fantasized about. This place, called Victory, defines itself with the words, “It’s the perfect place to build the family you’ve always wanted. In this sun-baked paradise.” In this world, alcohol is consumed in abundance; people have fun; they drive together through an utterly empty desert; wives see their husbands off to work every morning by kissing them and waving. In the evening, they welcome their husbands back from work by preparing all kinds of dishes, dressing in beautiful clothes, and holding a drink in their hands. High-protein meals are eaten continuously; food and beverages come from the company; houses and household items are selected from a catalogue; and as men’s levels within the organization rise, their cars and household furnishings become more luxurious.

For men who cannot find what they want in the real world, the world Frank has constructed is virtually a utopia. However, this world is a utopia built according to men’s dreams and fantasies—through a distinctly male imagination. In the film, this is expressed as: “Frank built something very special. What he created here

is something different. A different way. A better way.” It is also conveyed when, in response to Frank’s question “Whose world is this?”, the men shout in unison, “Ours.”

In Frank’s speeches—constantly dictated to the women and men within the system—there is a significant critique of chaos and an emphasis on order. In Victory, women who take a group ballet class are repeatedly given the message: “There is beauty in control. There is grace in symmetry. We move together.” According to Frank, the view that argues women and men are equal has pushed the modern world into chaos. For this reason, he says, “We can leave behind the chaos that reigns beneath the mindset of equality.” Accordingly, in this utopia he has established, he asserts that “everything is as it ought to be” and that it accords with the “hierarchy of nature.” What Frank refers to is the sharp separation of social roles between women and men. The fact that the security personnel—who attempt to prevent rebellious actions by women such as Margaret and Alice—wear red jumpsuits can be interpreted as a reference to the Red Pill movement. Moreover, the Victory central building, which residents of Victory are forbidden to enter, is a tower located at the highest point in the city: access is provided through a spiral turning movement; it is surrounded by mirrored glass; and its interior is not visible. This structure recalls Michel Foucault’s theory of the Panopticon. We may say that this symbolic tower—through which entrances to and exits from Victory are made—symbolizes that everyone within the system is under constant surveillance by unseen watchers.

Through the flashback technique, the film returns to Alice and Jack’s past lives. In these scenes, a comparison is drawn between the coldness and ordinariness of reality—along with its various problems—and the warm tones, bright colors, and apparent seamlessness of the men’s utopia. In the utopia, Alice is a housewife; in the real world, she is an assistant doctor who goes into surgeries. In stark contrast to her home in Victory, she lives with Jack in an old apartment with broken hot water, furnished in dark, faded colors. Although she tells her husband Jack, who has been laid off, “I can work overtime; it’s not a problem,” Alice has become someone who comes home late at night exhausted and only wants to rest. She describes her life as consisting of 30-hour shifts, 12 surgeries, and having to start work again in 6 hours. Consequently, she is unhappy, irritable, tired, and angry with her spouse. Jack—who is always well-groomed and wears a suit in Frank’s world—appears in reality in dirty, worn clothes at home. In real life, people cannot find the opportunity to live the life they deserve. Frank offers them, in this counterfeit heaven, the life they believe they deserve. In Frank’s virtual universe, men live exactly as they wish to appear themselves and as they wish to see their wives. The world Frank offers men allows them to live a fantasy they have always wanted to offer their wives, but one whose material standards are very difficult to attain in the real world. They offer themselves and their wives virtual happiness, even if it is not real. The scene in which Jack, after deciding to join the system, chooses his nationality and his car is important in that it shows the gap between who Jack is in reality and who he wants to be. Next to Jack’s computer—Jack, who wants his nationality to be British—there is a poster for the 1963 film *From Russia with Love* (*From Russia with Love*), the second installment of the James Bond series. In this film, British agent James Bond—consistent with the genre’s familiar conventions—constantly dresses elegantly, drinks alcohol, drives expensive cars, and is seen as an object of desire by all the women around him, easily seducing them. The poster includes the following lines: “Meet James Bond, secret agent 007, New incredible women... New incredible enemies... New incredible adventures...” When considered alongside the life Jack leads in Frank’s paradise, it becomes clearer that Jack harbors, in his unconscious, a desire to possess the unalloyed masculine traits and the life that James Bond embodies.

The Collapse of the Utopia

Alice, who gradually begins to understand that she has been imprisoned within a virtual reality, is left caught between the dilemma of great love and captivity. While Alice, who loves her husband, proposes a solution in the form of: “We can go anywhere; we can create our own world (...) what matters is that we are together,” Jack will choose to have his wife’s mind “washed” once again. However, thanks to the song Jack hums—and which has been on Alice’s mind for days—Alice fully remembers her former life. The song that has preoccupied her for days functions as a reminder belonging to the real world, indeed as a kind of doorway. Alice’s moment of illumination (epiphany), which also constitutes the film’s climax, is presented in the work as follows:

“Alice—What did you do? I had a life. You took my life.

Jack—You were always working. You were in a wreck, you were so unhappy, you hated your life!

Alice—It was my life. Mine! You can’t take it from me!”

Jack, trying to persuade his wife not to leave him, will insist that they are whole and perfect together. As he utters lines such as “We’re perfect here” and “Don’t you want to be perfect with me?”, he will press her tightly to his own body with both hands so that she will not go.

Figure 1.

Jack’s refusal to let Alice go in the film **Don’t Worry Darling**



In the scene where Jack grips his wife with all his strength, as if wanting to draw her into himself (Figure 1), one can see, on one hand, the wedding ring symbolizing the bond and fidelity between him and his spouse, and, on the other, the ring that Frank personally placed on his finger, symbolizing Jack’s loyalty to Frank. We may interpret these rings as symbolizing both Jack’s being torn between Alice and Frank and the fact that Frank’s dominance over Jack is equivalent to his relationship with his wife. This scene can be read together with Jack’s desire to become “one body” with his wife, and with the man’s desire in Asaf Hâlet’s poem “Kadinciğim” (“My Woman”) to make himself a spouse from his thigh bone. In this virtual world, Jack has enacted a symbolic birth: he has produced for himself the wife he has fantasized about. Now, however, Alice wants to exit this world—virtually a male paradise—and be free. Jack’s fastening Alice’s body to his own can be interpreted as a desire to take her back to the place from which she emerged—that is, back inside him. Hakan Kızıltan explains the relationship between the desire to attain ideal perfection and the idea of fusion and becoming one body as follows: “The ego’s fundamental aim, in order to reach absolute narcissism, is to take in the object onto which the ego ideal is projected, to merge with it, and to become one body with it...” (Kızıltan, 2011, p. 68).

Throughout the film, we frequently see Jack watching his wife Alice. The husband continually observes his wife’s happiness and beauty. Yet what he sees in her happiness is the glow of what he has been able to provide for her—even if only in a virtual world. In this sense, Alice functions almost like a mirror enabling Jack to see what he has achieved, we might—

One may argue that Alice's happiness is a reflection of Jack's victory as a man. This is also why the project—and the place where they live—was named "Victory." Slavoj Žižek examines this condition of reflection in the context of "courtly love": "Devoid of any real substance, the Lady functions as a mirror in which the subject reflects his own narcissistic ideal" (Žižek, 2006, p. 118). Despite all her problems, Alice chooses the life that belongs to her rather than the life Jack has scripted for her, and—albeit unintentionally—kills her husband by striking him on the head.

When we turn to the Frank–Alice relationship in which Jack is caught between them, Frank—although he could persuade Alice—regards her skepticism as a challenge to his own system and provokes her to attempt to break free. Frank frames Alice's questioning of the system she has constructed as a matter of masculine pride: "No great man has changed the course of history without having the limits of his potential pushed. And you are pushing me. Yes. I hope you keep doing it. But for now, you're making dinner here. Like a good girl," thereby encouraging Alice to struggle against him.

Although Frank says to his wife Shelley, "We men want a lot. We want power; we want a shoulder to cry on; we want food on the table; we want the house to be clean; and above all we want secrecy. And that is very hard. (Addressing his wife) You are my anchor. I couldn't be here without you. Thank you," the film's ending shows that even Frank—the architect of the system—is in fact speaking against the woman in his own mind. Just as he has produced an ideal world in his imagination, within this project he also creates a projection of his own idealization for his wife, whom he believes supports him.

After the death of Dr. Collins, his wife says, "You stupid man," and then, without a second thought, kills her husband with the knife she had just quietly been using to slice a lemon for his drink, adding, "Now it's my turn." This event can be read as indicating both that, even within the universe he himself has built, Frank can be dethroned when he loses power as a man, and that the mind that will construct virtual reality from here on will be not the male mind but the female mind. Moreover, despite her prolonged exposure to Frank's speeches glorifying patriarchy, it becomes apparent that even his own wife does not believe him.⁴

The film ends with Alice waking and the sound of a deep breath she draws into her lungs. Alice achieves victory over her husband, who has bound her hands and feet and confined her—without her consent—to another world. At this point, the title *Victory* comes to mean Alice's victory. Her liberation from that fabricated world into which she was forcibly imprisoned has not been easy at all. In the real world, she is still tethered to the bed, and the living conditions awaiting her are not easy. We understand that a difficult struggle continues as the film ends by foregrounding the sound of the heroine's breathless breathing. Freedom is not easy. With this message, the film ends.

Conclusion

There are striking similarities between Asaf Halet Çelebi's poem "Kadıncağım" and the film *Don't Worry Darling* in terms of men's fantasies of creating and controlling an ideal woman. These two works offer a parallel critique through the patriarchal mindset's desire to turn women into objects and the tragic consequences produced by that desire.

In both works, men create the ideal women they imagine with their own hands. In the poem "Kadıncağım," the man, "removing his thighbone"

makes himself a woman. This process of creation shows that the man shapes the woman solely to serve him. Similarly, in *Don't Worry Darling*, Jack transforms Alice—a real woman—into his ideal spouse by imprisoning her in a virtual world. Both works make it explicit that this act of creation erases women's individuality and reduces them to objects that satisfy men's desires.

In the poem "Kadıncağım," the man keeps the woman under control by "seating her on the shelf." Once the woman moves beyond the man's sphere of control, she begins to appear as a threat. In the film, by contrast, women are physically confined within a simulation, and their memories of their past lives have been erased. By aiming to make women forget their identities and freedoms, men force them to live under absolute authority.

Both works define woman through functionality. In the poem "Kadıncağım," the woman is merely a figure who meets the man's needs, as conveyed in the lines "she cooked my meals, she sewed my tears." In the film, women sustain their existence by doing housework, cooking, and serving men's utopias. This reveals that women are seen not as individuals, but as functional instruments.

Both works also show that these ideal worlds constructed by men ultimately collapse at a certain point. The woman in the poem, as a product of the cycle of loneliness and domination embedded in the man's creation, disturbs the man's peace. In the film, however, Alice gains her freedom by escaping the artificial world built by men. This demonstrates that patriarchal utopias are unsustainable, and that women's desire for freedom will, sooner or later, push against the limits of these structures.

Both works critique male domination over women as unsustainable and unjust. While the poem "Kadıncağım" emphasizes that this domination isolates the man, *Don't Worry Darling* shows women reclaiming their identities by rebelling against this domination. In both works, it is made clear that the patriarchal fantasy of the "ideal woman" created by the male-dominated world functions as a kind of prison for both men and women.

Reviewer Evaluation: External and independent.

Conflict of Interest: The author has declared no conflict of interest.

Financial Support: The author has declared that no financial support was received for this study.

Peer-review: Externally peer-reviewed.

Conflict of Interest: The author have no conflicts of interest to declare. **Financial Disclosure:** The author declared that this study has received no financial support.

References

- Çağın, S. (2021). From myth to literature: the reconstruction of women. *Çingeneler edebiyata girince*. *Dergâh Yayınları*, 127–148.
- Çelebi, A. H. (1998). *Bütün şiirleri* [*Collected Poems*]. YKY.
- Daştan, N. (2015). The appearance of the motif of expulsion from heaven in the Abrahamic religions and in certain mythologies (Sumerian, Turkish, and Greek). *Türklük Bilimi Araştırmaları*. (36), 61–81.
- Egrik, E. B. (2007). *Türk sinemasında pygmalion etkisi* [The Pygmalion effect in Turkish cinema] (Thesis No. 208527) [Master's thesis, Marmara University]. Council of Higher Education National Thesis Center. <https://tez.yok.gov.tr/UlusalTezMerkezi/tezSorguSo-nucYeni.jsp>
- Kırımlı, B. (1994). *Asaf Halet Çelebi (hayatı eserleri, sanatı ve fikirleri)* [Asaf Halet Çelebi (his life, works, art, and ideas)] (Thesis No. 36886) [Master's thesis, Atatürk University]. Council of Higher Education National Thesis Center. <https://tez.yok.gov.tr/UlusalTezMerkezi/tez-SorguSonucYeni.jsp>

⁴ A connection can also be made between this scene and the 2015 film *Ex Machina*. In both works, the men—whose physical and mental strength and control over everything are emphasized throughout—are easily killed at an unexpected moment by women beside them whom they assume will not harm them, using the knives the women hold for preparing food. In both films, it is similarly portrayed how easily the male body can be wounded by the knife, which represents the power of steel, despite its size, as well as the men's shock in the face of this unexpected attack.